ECON 490: *Capstone Proposal Activity*

In this activity, we'll get some practice brainstorming capstone project ideas. One of the key skills in identifying a potential project idea is being able to generate multiple ideas. You can then assess whether the project is viable (i.e., is relevant data available?) and pick the project that is most promising.

To get started, carefully review the Capstone Data Resources page. Then, do the following:

1) Identify a data set or link that describes a topic in which you're interested (for this activity, try to find data sets/links that are directly available for download).
2) Define a correlation/relationship that is potentially interesting using the variables/columns included in the data set you've selected.
3) Try to apply the idea of "exploring variation" to think about what differences might be interesting in the correlation you've identified (i.e., Does the relationship depend on some other characteristic or variable in the data set? Does it vary across time/states/types of people?).

Individual Project Idea

After going through the steps above, respond to the following questions:

1) What data set did you decide to use? What made you interested in that data set?

2) What correlation/relationship would you estimate with this data? Why is this interesting/what might it tell us?

3) How would you apply the idea of exploring variation to expand the correlation analysis in question 2? What other characteristics might mediate or impact the correlation you estimate in question 2?

Group Project Idea

PARTNER'S NAME: _____

Working with someone else, come up with a new/distinct project idea. This idea should use new data sets *not* covered by either of your individual project ideas. Respond to the same questions above, describing this new idea.

NOTE: Only one of you needs to complete these questions. Make sure to write the other person's name.

1) What data set did you decide to use? What made you interested in that data set?

2) What correlation/relationship would you estimate with this data? Why is this interesting/what might it tell us?

3) How would you apply the idea of exploring variation to expand the correlation analysis in question 2? What other characteristics might mediate or impact the correlation you estimate in question 2?

4) Use the AI prompt posted on GitHub to evaluate your group's idea. Email me a link for your group's conversation thread (most AI platforms have an option to share conversations). Ideally, using a "Pro"-level model with reasoning capability (i.e., use Thinking mode in ChatGPT/Gemini). In the space below, briefly describe the quality of feedback you received. Was it helpful?